

GANDHI-IN-WAITING

- Finally realises in March 2007 that there is more to Uttar Pradesh than the family fiefdoms of Amethi and Rae Bareilly. Leads the Congress campaign for the state polls but the party's tally falls from 25 to 22. Makes a few political gaffes, but partyworkers are exuberant that the young scion is finally showing signs of leadership.
- Is made party general secretary in September. Like his father and uncle, takes charge of the youth wing. Is also made a member of the group on future challenges, where he helps draft a blueprint for the future and takes up issues like the Ram Sethu and reservations.
- Campaigns for the Gujarat and the Himachal Pradesh elections in December. The Congress fails to win either state.
- Begins the New Year with a visit to the drought-affected Bundelkhand in Uttar Pradesh and laments that because of corruption, not even five paise of a rupee spent on the poor actually reach them.
- Spends the Republic Day weekend with children in an Amethi hospital and a night out at a Dalit household. Later, Mayawati mocks him by saying he washes himself with a special soap after meeting Dalits.
- Meets the media over a well-choreographed impromptu lunch, where he stresses the need to involve youth in decision-making within the party.
- Asks for an extension of the NREG scheme and gets it. Embarks on a tour of India. Takes off without security cover to meet tribals in Orissa. Admitting that his surname has helped him, talks of the need for democracy within the party.
- Spends five days wooing farmers in poll-bound Karnataka.

doubt that he will eventually fulfil Singh's wish. Yet, he hesitates to take up the leadership mantle. The 37-year-old delayed attending the Uttar Pradesh Congress meet in Kanpur by a day until he was assured there would be no clamour to project him as the prime ministerial candidate for the 2009 elections. After the Uttar Pradesh Assembly elections fiasco, Rahul seems to have realised that spending his teen years in London and his holidays in South America has not prepared him for the Dalits of Uttar Pradesh and the tribals of Orissa.

It is exactly this stop-gap period, while Rahul grooms himself for Race

game. They are both positioning themselves for a beyond-Manmohan and before-Rahul scenario. This is a game Singh has played before, with another non-Gandhi prime minister. After Rajiv's death in 1991, Singh was the first to suggest Sonia as prime minister, but she gave Narasimha Rao the job.

Unlike with Manmohan, though, there was no division of power between the PMO and the party president during Rao's prime ministership. He held both posts. And unlike Manmohan, he had his own coterie of Congressmen who stymied



MANEESH AGNIHOTRI

FAMILY MATTERS: Sonia and Rahul at a Congress session in Kanpur

Course Road, that Manmohan's colleagues are clamouring for. Says a Congress general secretary, "Sonia's renunciation in 2004 took everyone by surprise. Before anyone could lobby for the job, she had named Manmohan. Now Singh's target is 2009. He is building his acceptability through OBC politics and blatant sycophancy." According to this leader, Singh is hoping that pressure from the allies could work against Manmohan and in his favour, in case a Congress-led coalition comes back to power.

When he realised that he was losing out in the loyalty sweepstakes, Mukherjee quickly caught on to Singh's

Singh's prime ministerial plans. Not only Manmohan's Cabinet, but his PMO, too, is filled with 10 Janpath yes men.

The Congress spokesman may claim there is no room for sycophancy. But there is more than enough space for die-hard family loyalists. And with the general elections not far away, the family must retain its space in the popular mind. Gandhi—whether it is Rahul as the hesitant prince or Priyanka as a pilgrim to the prison that houses one of the conspirators in her father's assassination—is everywhere. Such a scenario warms the heart of a mischievous Arjun Singh. The other Singh suffers in silence.